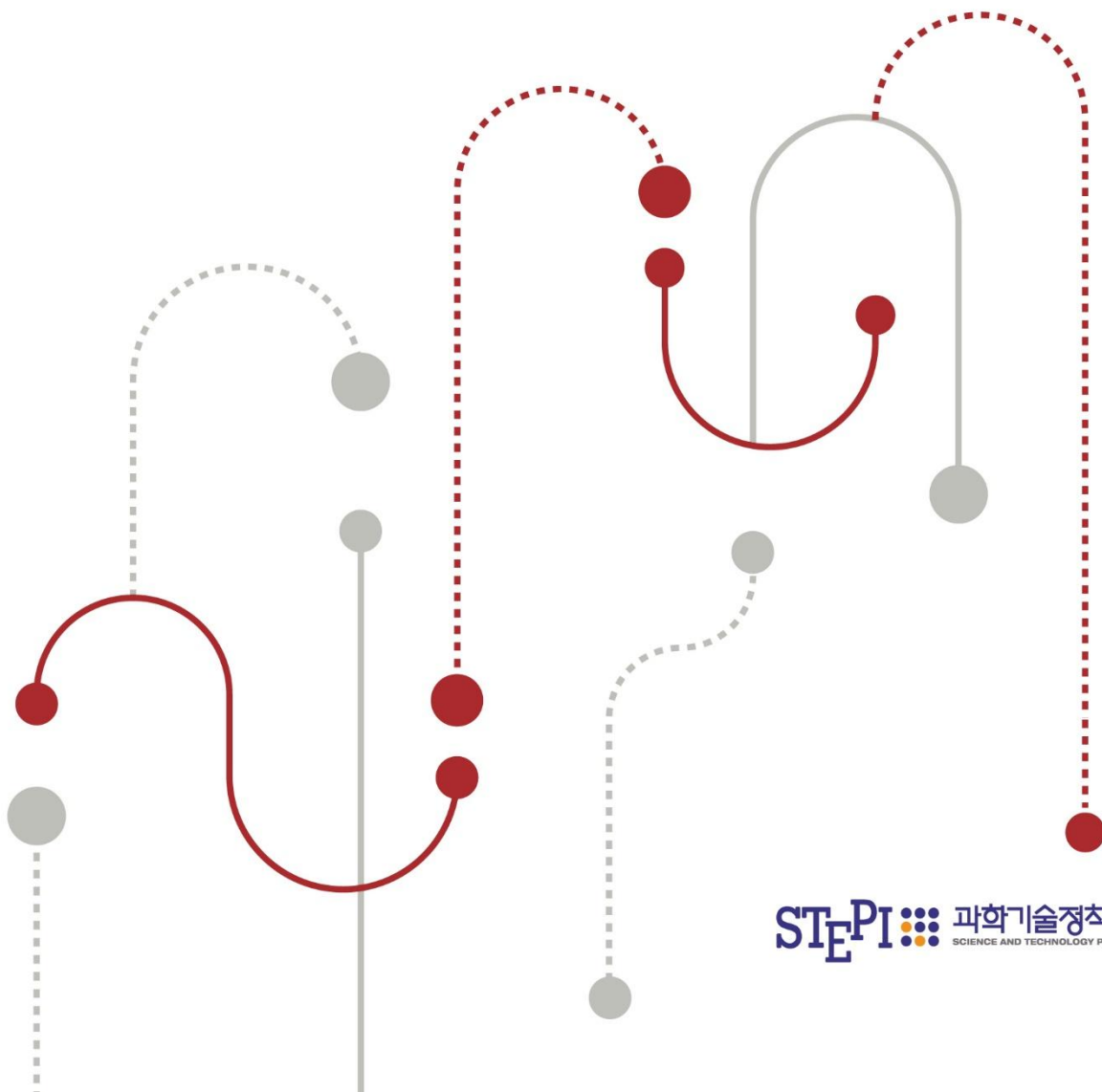


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Inclusive Innovation Diplomacy in a Transformative Era: Co-Creating Innovation Partnerships with the Global South



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Sohyun Kwon, Hwanil Park, Youna Lee

SUMMARY

Inclusive Innovation Diplomacy in a Transformative Era: Co-Creating Innovation Partnerships with the Global South

Sohyun Kwon, Hwanil Park, Youna Lee

■ Global South: A Strategic Partner for Korea in Responding to Shifts in the Global Economic and Technological Landscape

- Background and Rationale
 - The international environment is undergoing a profound transformation, driven in part by intensifying competition for technological leadership between the United States and China. In this context, Korea faces an urgent need to redefine its role in the global community and to strengthen its capacity for strategic risk management.
 - While Korea's long-standing framework of security cooperation with the United States and economic interdependence with China is unlikely to change rapidly, Korea requires multidimensional mid- to long-term strategies to secure new growth engines, enhance national innovation capabilities, and contribute effectively to sustainable development.
 - Korea is particularly well positioned to assume the role of a middle-power leader for inclusive global innovation, given its dual experience in: science- and technology-driven economic development, and development cooperation and assistance.
- Why the Global South Matters
 - The Global South has emerged as an increasingly critical strategic partner for Korea, particularly in the context of science, technology, and innovation (STI) cooperation. This is underpinned by several structural factors:
 - Demographics: A young population base and an expanding working-age population are expected to strengthen long-term growth potential.

- Strategic resources: Many Global South countries possess key strategic assets, including critical minerals essential to energy transition and advanced industries, as well as globally significant biodiversity and biological resources.
- Rising economic weight: The Global South's share of global GDP is expected to expand substantially by 2050, narrowing the gap with advanced economies.
- Growing STI capacity: Research output in the Global South is rapidly increasing, however, qualitative gaps remain in areas such as research influence and top-tier journal publication.
- Establishing a “Korea-Context Global South”: Definition and Scope
 - This report proposes a “Korea-context Global South” definition that extends beyond a development assistance framework. Under this approach, the Global South refers to countries that exhibit political and social stability, possess a baseline level of economic and STI capability, and can pursue meaningful STI cooperation with Korea in addressing global challenges such as climate change, biodiversity, digital transformation, and health.
 - Cooperation modalities should not be confined to capacity-building and training. They should also include joint research, researcher exchange, and the establishment of sustainable cooperation platforms.

■ Global South STI Agendas and Emerging Tensions in Global Governance

- The Global South is increasingly positioning itself not as a passive recipient of external support, but as an equal partner in sustainable development and global problem solving. In this context, it is also emerging as a co-shaper of global rules, standards, and the technological order.
- Global South priorities in STI governance frequently emphasize inclusive innovation (including DEIA: diversity, equity, inclusion, and accessibility), open innovation and equitable access to technology and data, climate action, health security, and biodiversity protection.

- These agendas can generate structural tension with some advanced economies, particularly around innovation leadership (IP protection, standard- setting, security), versus innovation access (technology transfer, data access, equity and fairness).

■ **Priority Partner Countries for STI Cooperation: Evidence-Based Identification**

- Analytical Approach
 - The report identifies countries with high potential for strategic STI cooperation by applying comparative analysis across indicators related to economic and political/social foundations, STI capabilities, and domain- specific capacities for responding to global challenges (climate, digital, health).
 - From the 133 G77 countries, 13 countries across regions (Latin America, Africa, Asia, Middle East/Europe) were selected based on existing literature and assessed using international indicators. Countries were comparatively analyzed along two dimensions: Economic growth and cooperation capacity, and Science, technology, and innovation (STI) capacity
 - Based on this framework, four country groups were identified, each requiring differentiated cooperation strategies.
- Key Findings
 - First, Pioneer Partners - including India, Saudi Arabia, Malaysia, Türkiye, and Brazil - represent countries with strong capabilities in both economic growth and science, technology, and innovation (STI). For this group, Korea should prioritize co-creation and joint leadership.
 - Second, Scaling Partners - such as Indonesia, Mexico, and Egypt - are characterized by robust economic growth but comparatively limited STI capacity. Korea's strategy should focus on scaling and technology transfer.
 - Third, Innovation Leverage Partners - including Thailand and Russia -possess relatively strong STI capabilities but face constraints in economic growth or market

expansion. For this group, Korea should pursue a strategy of leveraging innovation by combining technological strengths with market- oriented collaboration.

- Finally, Emerging Priority Partners - such as South Africa, Argentina, and Nigeria - face limitations in both economic and STI capacity and are therefore key targets for long-term development cooperation. Korea's approach should focus on building foundational capacity, including investments in basic infrastructure, human resource development, and institutional strengthening.

■ **Policy Recommendations: Building a “Co-Creation Innovation Partnership”**

- Strategic Shift
 - Korea should transition from aid-centered cooperation and one-way technology transfer toward a co-creation partnership model in which partners jointly execute the full cycle including problem identification, solution design, piloting and validation, diffusion and scaling.
- Three Strategic Objectives
 - Strengthen joint problem-solving capacity for global challenges
 - Support the establishment of self-reliant innovation systems in partner countries (capability internalization)
 - Enhance Korea's strategic interests and reinforce its middle-power leadership through sustained STI partnerships
- Step-by-Step Implementation Strategy
 - Short-term (2-3 years): Establish governance structures (Presidential-level committee; sectoral task forces) and launch quick-win pilot projects linked to MDB financing.
 - Mid-term (3-5 years): Build STI cooperation hubs in core countries and develop integrated platforms combining R&D, policy advisory, talent development, and business entry support.

- Long-term (5-10 years): Develop flagship programs for climate, digital, health, and food, and institutionalize high-level Korea–Global South STI cooperation frameworks.